1.

I think the corniest cliché for an opening scene is:

Morning. A clock. The kind of alarm clock with big red digits. The time is 8:59 a.m. A nasty synthetic beep-beep-beep-beep goes off, and the hero's hand, with deliberate clumsiness, tries to reach it, knocking over some stuff and the alarm clock itself.

In this scene the alarm is switched off with one precise movement.

This is how the author wants to show that the hero has precisely planned his morning and everything's generally under his control. Or at least that's what he thinks.

The word "hero" pisses me off, and spinning out this pretentious discourse about deconstructing the traditional hero, the search for an everyday hero, the antihero, the meta-hero and blah-blah-blah is the last fucking thing anybody needs, so the word "hero" is now going to appear in this text for the last time.

The hero turns off the alarm.

He is lying on an IKEA couch on a gray IKEA sheet. The fitted kind, with elastic on all four sides. In the evening, when he was pulling two of its corners over the couch and trying to get the third one on, the first two kept popping off, and he had to start all over again. Sometimes this battle goes on for a very long time.

His name is Igor. He is 36 years old. He is lying on a couch in a flat at

81673, Weihenstephaner Straße 10, Munich.

Why so many details?

This is supposed to be a documentary play. My name really is Igor. I turn off the alarm on my phone and see that my boyfriend is heading out somewhere at 9 a.m. In answer to my question "Where are you going?" he says he's arranged a quickie.

Rostislav. I won't be long. You don't mind?

I say I don't, even though I barely understand what's going on, whether I'm even awake, and, most importantly, whether I really don't mind.

We've been together for three years, and for the last six months we've been in an open relationship.

Igor. The sound of the front door closing. Pause. Igor lies on the gray sheet and stares at the ceiling.

Igor Sergeev

Open relationship

A documentary play

Translated from the Russian by Rostislav Godlevsky

2.

Igor. I open Gr[ee]ndr. Actually, it's pronounced Gr[ai]ndr, but in Saint Petersburg I used to say it like that.

It's a dating app, people here are mostly just looking for sex.

Meanwhile, "grind" means to mince or to crush. What did they mean when they named the app that?

All profiles are just photos.

First one. a guy. 26, standing against a mountain backdrop.

Second profile. No face. 39 years old. profile with a photo of a river and the sun. "Spontaneous and horny when I'm online. I'm a top and I like outdoor activities. But not only that. Text me."

Third profile. Pumped bare torso in black and white. No face. shot from below as if you're kneeling before him.

Igor. Not bad

Fourth one. a guy in a dog mask. I like it WRAFF! barking in: English

Fifth. Cute guy with a beard and a cap standing in a chandelier museum.

Next profile. A guy staring directly into the camera. Medium close-up shot.

Head shaved clean.

Blue eyes and unruly eyebrows. You can't see it in the photo, but one of his eyes is partly brown.

In the nose, a silvery ring.

Beard. Big lips, especially the bottom one. Mouth slightly open. He often does that during sex.

Big silver rings with a ball in each ear.

In this photo he's shirtless. Broad and slightly muscular shoulders. All his life he's worried that he's too skinny, goes to the gym and really wants to be a hulking wall of muscle. But now he's lost some weight again and I love it.

I have a savior complex and I always liked guys who, through how they looked and behaved, signaled that they needed to be pulled out of the inescapable abyss like right now. I understand that it's not okay.

His nickname in the app is an emoji of two crossed swords. Actually, his name is Rostislav. My boyfriend, who just arranged a quickie.

300m away.
Now online.

Stats

- Height: 182cm
- Weight: 68kg
- Status: Open relationship

The app tracks the location in real time. Now he's already 500m away. 700m. 1km. and will soon disappear from Grindr's profile grid.

3.

Rostislav. You see him on Grindr, like, the body's great, you ask for face pics and then it's some really mediocre guy with his face.

Igor. What do you mean "mediocre"? Like, it doesn't fit the body?

Rostislav. Yeah, like, I don't know. It might even fit the body. Fuck knows what 'fitting the body' even means. But like, it just doesn't.. The face really matters, after all. It's like this whole connection thing, kind of...

Igor. Did you have that connection with my face? Just tell it like it is.

Rostislav. I think so. Probably, with the face first of all, actually.

Igor. How come?

Rostislav. Well, just.. it's a beautiful face, to me.

Igor. Spill it.

Rostislav. Well, the main thing is it probably looks sort of trustworthy to me. Or, maybe, I don't know. I'm gonna be saying all of this now, because I know you already and I've been looking at your face for three years at this point, so kinda... Fuck knows. Did you seem trustworthy to me back then, before I knew you? I don't really remember. Maybe yes. There was something about you, uhm, like kind of... Unattainable even, drawing me in. That you've got these beautiful fucking blue eyes. And on the whole, it's like kinda harmonious, sort of, calm.

4.

Isarvorstadt is a central district of Munich, along the Isar river. It's like the Fontanka in Petersburg.

A very jittery guy, a little over forty. Photos of his husband on every side of the bedroom. Pretty much looking at us, banging each other. At the moment the husband's on tour. Turns out, he doesn't know his boyfriend can bring someone home. He didn't mention it before.

5.

Igor. Three years ago I was living in Saint-Petersburg. That's where Rost and I met. I come to the theater, my play is on today. I see our technical director interviewing some guy for the job. I've never seen him here before.

Acting like I'm just going about my business, I walk by. I walk by again. And again. Again. Once more. Feels like I'm totally getting clocked, but I can't help myself.

The interview ends and I pounce on her with questions:

- Who was that?

- Rostislav. A new tech, maybe a sound engineer.

- He's not gay, is he?

- Nah, definitely not.

After that story I probably come across as a total creep.

Rost has been working at the theater for about a month now. Another show has just ended. The crew is striking the set, my co-author and I are sitting in the office, Rost walks by us holding a projector and, for some reason, suddenly gives us a silent, mysterious smile, while we're sitting right next to each other. Leaves.

We've no idea what just happened. Which one of us was he smiling at?

We make a deal that next time he walks in we'll both smile back and that'll clear things up.

I am absolutely certain I don't stand a chance.

He walks in again, smiles again, we silently smile back. From outside it must look like some kind of nuthouse. He leaves again and my friend says that she's sure as hell lost this game.

That same evening the two of us go to "Zaliv". Sitting at the bar drinking countless nastoyka shots, I suggest we go to mine.

On our way we stop to buy some smokes, he buys camel blue and I think: "how is that possible?" They're the only ones I've smoked for the last several years.

When you're very alike, it's great.

But in some things it's better to be completely different, otherwise, at some point, handling a bunch of problems in emigration will be impossible for two people who are so alike.

6.

Schwabing. A neighborhood north of central Munich.

A student from Turkey. He was really worried that he didn't speak German well. And my English is awful. Turns out he'd lived in Tolyatti for a few years and speaks Russian.

7.

Igor. I am in the middle of this documentary playwriting course and by the end of it I have to finish this play.

After the first lecture I realize that eventually I'll have to write a piece that treats interviews, documents and diaries with great care and diligence. From all of this I, for some reason, decide that there's no room left for me in this play. That's when I start to get angry.

In addition to that, it's a massive problem for me to talk about myself. About how I'm really doing. About what I'm thinking and feeling right now. About my work, my ups and downs.

Until you ask me

Until you honestly ask me:

"how are you?"

I can just listen for hours. I tell myself: it's okay, I'm modest and I'm fighting my huge ego. But in reality I want you to ask me:

"How are you? I really want to know how you're actually doing right now?"

And then I'll pour it all out on you.

All this sounds especially great in a text where I've been talking only about myself for six pages straight.

If you keep suppressing something inside you your whole life, at some point it's gonna burst out for sure.

And then Jeffrey Dahmer, suppressing his homosexuality, will invite Steven Hicks over for a beer, hit him over the head with a dumbbell and eat his liver in a red wine and thyme sauce, with a side of fried Jerusalem artichoke.

Or, well, you'll write a play about yourself and your open relationship, treat yourself to this self-indulgent sentence about Jeffrey Dahmer, and finally tell everyone how you're actually doing.

8.

Moosach. Northwest of the city

Designer. We see each other a lot. I teach him Russian, he teaches me German. I'm crazy about his tiny apartment. It feels like time stopped there in 2005 and you're on Komenda in St. Pete's.

9.

Igor. A couple days after mobilization started, Rost said that if they came for him or grabbed him on the street, he'd slit his wrists.

But first there was February 24th. My English teacher's from Kyiv, and like three weeks before the 24th I'm telling her, totally sure of myself, that if our grandpa starts a war, it's all gonna crumble here.

Feb. 24th at 6:12am I receive a voice message from her:

"Good morning. It's started here. If possible, do something. Please, try something to make it stop."

Second or third rally.

We go around the cosmonauts, that’s what we call the riot cops, through little side streets and courtyards, and at a traffic light this old lady asks:

- What’s all the shouting about?

We say: “No to war and all that”

And she’s like: “What war?”

Rost and I figure, okay, maybe that happens, maybe she just doesn’t know. Dead serious, we tell her what’s going on. She listens really carefully, doesn’t interrupt, and then says:

“We didn’t start no war, we, actually, are ending it.”

And then, for the first time from a live human being on the street, I hear the ‘eight years’ mantra.

And even then we’re still hoping for something.

10.

Haidhausen. East of Munich.

I’m here the most. It’s close to home and looks a bit like Petersburg.

A couple. Both over forty and been together for ages. The most textbook successful gay couple, straight out of a commercial. Great sex, never saw them again.

11.

Igor. You call this a life?

I'm a king without a kingdom. I will raise an army of Normans and land in England. Is it the great Harald Sigurdsson?

Will you join?

flubbed that, let's go again.

Rostislav. Oh yeah, I'd join.

Igor. You'd join this sexy beefcake?

Rostislav. Yeah.

Igor. I think you're scared to fight me. Someday, Viking, your quick...

let's go again.

Someday, Viking, your quick tongue will not be quick enough to save you.

Igor. Well yeah, I get it, a huge beefed-up sexy jock. You'd hook up with him?

Rostislav. Yes.

Igor. And you'd definitely be happy if I was like that too, wouldn't you? With a fuckton of muscles?

Rostislav. I dunno, it'd be interesting. Well, yeah, my tentacles, they're all just…

Igor. Swelling up.

Rostislav. Uh-huh

Igor. Right, let's keep recording.

We'll put this scene on pause for a moment.

I work as a voice actor and that's exactly what's happening above.

But I wanted to say something else. About how the episodes are cut together.

War - TV-series - talks about sex.

That's pretty much what insta stories look like right now.

Avocado toast - bombed-out children's hospital - beach party

I. I think you're scared to fight me. Someday, Viking, your quick…

let's go again.

Someday, Viking, your quick tongue will not be quick enough to save you.

Do you know the difference between hunger and appetite? Hunger is what our body tells us we need. Appetite is what we want.

And would it be a big blow for you if I suddenly went and banged some big jacked dude like that and suddenly fell in love?

Rostislav. Well yeah, would probably be unpleasant.

Igor. Would it be more unpleasant than if he wasn't like that?

Rostislav. I mean, of course, if you were to fall for someone who I found attractive, it would be harder for me than if I didn't find them attractive. Like, it's not about whether he's a jacked jock or whoever else. You're trying to twist it all again. Let's keep recording.

Igor. Let's. It is a Christian world now. No place left for believers in the gods. That is why we are here, to find a new home.

12.

Fürstenried. South-west Munich. The city ends right past it.

Another couple. Waiters. They work together. Next day one of them hints at meeting up without the other, looks like his partner doesn't know about it.

13.

September 2022.

Rost says that if they came for him or grabbed him on the street, he'd slit his wrists.

We bought tickets to Vladikavkaz, and from there it's Upper Lars and Georgia.

Exactly 24 hours to pack. In one day we stuffed our whole life into trash bags and took it to storage. We're in a taxi at night, going to the train station, I'm looking at the city and wondering if there's any guarantee I'll ever see all this again.

Back then I didn't know for sure if I had an exit ban on me or not. Trying to figure this out through lawyers, but it's the same hell and chaos there as everywhere else. The whole way I'm trying to convince Rost that if they don't let me out, he goes on without me and I go back to Petersburg and we'll sort it out later.

From Vladikavkaz to Lars we went by bike and got to the checkpoint by nightfall. And we were lucky at that, because of the bikes. The line of cars hasn't moved for days, and the vibe in the Upper Lars chat was like:

"They say the border is closed, is it true?"

"Guys, I beg you, let my wife and three kids through, one's a baby. Food's out, gas is almost out."

"Please don't just walk past, give whatever food and drinks you've got"

“one man helped us find food. i can share his number. he can help with lots of things”

“Guys, morning y’all, can you drink the water from those pipes sticking out of the mountain?”

“It’s a sewer”

“I think you can, it’s spring water. Our guys drank it. For sure not sewage”

“Lower Lars, don’t let the locals into the oncoming lane!!! Get out there and be a human shield!!!Don’t you get that they’re the reason you haven’t moved in a whole day? The people ahead of you have been waiting even longer, they’re about to run out of gas and then everything’s stuck for good!!”

And so it’s 3am and we’re in line on the finish stretch to passport control.

R. You could already hear from the start of the line how one of the officers was, let’s just say, doing her job more emotionally than everyone else, so I was kinda scared of her. I was just praying I wouldn’t get her, because, like, you could smell the fire coming from that little booth of hers. My turn comes, and I realize I’m going straight to her. By her voice she was this, like, imposing woman, but a real grump. I was picturing your classic government-office lady. I come up to the counter and, somewhat taken aback, see her huge long nails, this, like, absolutely luxurious kind of makeup, and in general she appeared much younger than she sounded. I hand over my passport. First she asks, like, my date of birth, and then my father’s name, which makes me stop and think a bit, because sure, I have a patronymic, but I don’t really use my father’s name in life, ‘cause he’s not in my life. So I’m like:

‘Ummm, Yuri, I think.’ And then she asks me something that makes me start wondering how real any of this is. She looks at me and asks: What’s your star sign? Aquarius, I say. She gives me back my passport and says ‘Have a good trip.’ I say thanks.

I. While we were in line, I was watching how it all worked up ahead and thinking if they let him through and not me, we’ll only get to say goodbye from a distance, through the turnstiles.

I walk up to the counter. Hand out my papers.

The border guard asks:

What’s my name? Where was I born?

Tells me to hold my head straight for the camera, and the whole time I’m answering she looks at the screen, then at me, says nothing, back at the screen, back at me, says nothing. Feels like it’s been going on forever. No idea what that was, maybe she’s got some kind of lie detector in that camera, but she sure knows how to build suspense.

Asks where else I’ve been. I start listing: Estonia, Finland, Belarus, Germany, Israel, Egypt. At some point I freeze up, but I guess that’s all she needs - she just stamps it and lets me through.

I even got through faster than Rost. But then they let him through too. And he kisses me right there past the checkpoint, in front of everyone.

14.

According to a study published in the Journal of Social and Personal Relationships in 2018, couples in open relationships don’t show a significantly higher breakup rate than monogamous couples.

15.

Haidhausen.

Classic gym jock. Really hard to tell how old he is: maybe 40, maybe 50 or even more. Decided not to ask. Very emotional and all over the place. Leaving, it turned out we go to the same gym.

16.

It was only after six months of open relationship that we realized we should probably agree on some clear rules. Each of us is allowed sex on the side, but our relationship comes first, and whatever happens out there shouldn’t turn into romantique. If romantique suddenly shows up on the horizon, we tell each other right away.

For me it’s important that we give each other a heads-up about possible sex in advance. And the main thing is that each of us can always say it’s not okay for him right now, and that it would be taken normally.

And when one of us gets back from one of these outings, he usually tells some exciting story about how it all went.

17.

Igor. One a.m.

I’m sitting alone at a bar. Scrolling Grindr. I never text anyone first. But everyone texting me right now is way off. I go outside for a smoke.

A message on Grindr:

Martin. 0 Meter entfernt. Du liest die Nachricht, während ich sie schreibe.

Igor. Fun. Wo bist du?

He’s somewhere really close. Zero meters from me, and he can see me reading his message.

I’m standing by the window, but I can’t see where he is.

Oh, there he is, a guy with a ‘stache and a cap.

In person he’s even cuter.

He’s smiling at me.

No idea how to react.

He’s with friends. I go back in, sit back down at the bar. Trying to check him out without getting clocked. He sees it.

Okay, fine. I keep drinking my beer, scrolling Grindr, if he wants to he’ll text or come over. He’s here with friends, after all.

Drinking beer

Scrolling Grindr

Drinking beer

Scrolling Grindr

Beer’s gone. He’s still with his friends, but I think he’s forgotten about me by now. Time to head home.

Someone sits down next to me. It’s him.

He asks:

“How am I doing?”

I say not great.

My German is terrible, but I tell him I have to speak it, or I’ll never learn it. I keep asking him to say everything again, he patiently explains it all.

He asks why I’m sad. Right off the bat I pour it all out on him, about me and Rost and our open relationship, and how there’s been some weird shit between us lately.

Martin switches into therapist mode. Half an hour later I feel totally calm, more so than ever. Now we’re already kissing for some reason. He’s from Berlin, came to Munich for work, says he’s sleeping at the office tonight.

I say an office is great, a real thrill ride, let’s go to your office. He plays coy, it’s awkward for him, there’s only a tiny stupid couch there. But here we are, already heading to that office. He jokingly calls me Schlampe, back then I don’t know yet what that is. But I’ll be calling him Schlampe every time we meet after that, until he says it’s actually starting to scare him. But I’m just like a kid, repeating my first swears in a foreign language.

18.

Igor. Well, this thought that people have sex, they get closer, find a lot in common, spend time together and something might happen. Doesn't that thought cross your mind when I go to someone?

Rostislav. It does cross my mind, but it doesn't bother me that much. It's like I'm kind of pretty... I dunno, like... shit, like somehow I…

Igor. Go nuclear.

Rostislav. Well, if we're going nuclear, then there's kind of two things at the same time. The first thing is that I'm kind of confident enough in our relationship. And that I kinda have some faith that you won't actually leave.

And the second thought is that I'm not fucking confident in our relationship at all. And that if you leave, who knows what happens after. Maybe it'll actually be better that way, for you or for me.

And also what I wanted to say is that it's like a risk I'm taking so I get to have all of this myself.

Igor. And why are you confident in our relationship?

Rostislav. Well that, like, I don't stress about it that much. And I don't stress about you liking it with someone else more than with me.

Igor. Because you think that…

Rostislav. That you still love me a lot.

Igor. But what if it happens that I suddenly meet someone who fits all my puzzle pieces right away better than you, like he suddenly has something I'm missing in you?

Rostislav. If that happens, then I guess I was wrong to be so confident. And then I'm probably like "Well fuck, I was wrong" and I start suffering over it.

Igor. So I somehow give you this confidence?

Rostislav. Well yeah.

Igor. How?

Rostislav. I feel like by answering that question I'm kind of shrinking that confidence right now. Because I'll answer it and you'll be like "Aha, so, I'm not doing that anymore."

Igor. Well, look, I don't have much of that confidence, for example. Share some of yours.

Rostislav. Well, you often tell me that this is the best relationship, that you're super happy, that you love me so very much. And I feel all that too, that it's true.

Does that make you feel like... Damn, how do I put this? Well, basically, like I'm kind of somewhat... Like I'm kind of above you, no?

Igor. Can you be a bit more specific?

Rostislav. Well, I have the confidence and you don't, but at the same time I both have it and don't. Like, does that make you feel uncomfortable?

Igor. That I'm less confident and because of that somehow dependent on you?

Rostislav. Well, something like that, yeah. Is that a thing?

Igor. Yeah, that's definitely a thing.

19.

Outskirts of Munich. We're walking down a country road. Bavarian fields all around, the Alps should be somewhere over there, the sun's going down. Yeah, I think it's that exact cheesy postcard of Germany from a souvenir shop. The three of us are walking: Rost, our friend Kolya and me. That's, of course, not his actual name, but he agreed to talk about his relationship on the record. There's almost a 30-year age gap between them.

Rostislav. But what keeps you two together now?

Kolya. That's my question too, one I'd like to ask him, and I'm gonna ask him soon. Like, why are we together? I'm waiting to hear back about my citizenship, saving up money.

Igor. So for you it's settled, that you two aren't gonna be together?

Kolya. It was settled a while ago.

Rostislav. Then why do you want to ask him that?

Kolya. What are we together for? So he can figure it out for himself first of all, I guess.

Rostislav. Well, it's just that it could, like, shake up all this stability you've more or less got right now. I mean, you're saying it's important for you to wait for the citizenship. And if you ask that, he might say just "goodbye", for example.

Kolya. Be my guest, God, I'll be gone on the first train, the first bus. I'm ready.

Rostislav. But then why…

Kolya. Not just say it openly?

Rostislav. If he says goodbye then you'll say "thank God". Why keep all of this now?

Kolya. The question is, this what? Maybe I just haven't gotten to the point yet where I'm ready. Where I'll be ready emotionally. For that kind of answer. Because I think, like, the last time we talked, when I brought up specific stuff, it sets off this storm of emotions in him right away. Like life is really falling apart.

I'll tell you what I'm missing in this relationship. I get it, like, say I live in a great house, I've got an awesome job, I've got a dog there. I get to travel, now I even get to hang out with whatever friends I want. Why change anything? I'm missing a person at home I'd want to hug. No, actually, here's the main thing. Nobody hugs me. I was just thinking, God, am I really such a bitch? Or are people scared of me? I even remember this one moment, we were in Austria, ski season. And this guy we know, he came with his boyfriend. We woke up and made breakfast. They woke up too. And our friend comes out of the room, comes over, and I'm already sitting at the table. He comes up from behind, hugs me and says it's so nice here, thank you so much. And even that moment really touched me. So, yeah, there's no closeness. A dog's good for walks. But a person, I think, is still better

Igor. So in the morning you get up, go your separate ways, at night you go to bed. Each in your own room.

Kolya. Exactly.

Rostislav. Sounds like for him it's just, you know, enough that there's just someone in the house.

Kolya. Yeah

Igor. Have you ever tried saying that you need to be hugged, I want you to hug me?

Kolya. I, actually, never told him that. Maybe sort of indirectly I did, about other people. Like, say, when I'd see guys walking holding hands and he'd immediately be like 'Schwuchtel'. And you are? And another moment comes to mind. When we were in Valencia, and for me, after Moscow, that was a breath of freedom. We were walking and I tried to hold his hand, it was so unpleasant for him that for me that was already the first red flag. Okay, maybe he's embarrassed that we've got such a big age gap.

Igor. But it's like you still think that he'll figure it all out, that he needs to hug you.

Kolya. I can't say if I told him openly or not about it. That I need it, what I don't. If you put it like that, then yeah, maybe it's partly my fault. Yeah, no, it's not my fucking fault at all.

20.

Berg am Laim. East Munich.

A government official. Told me up front that the sex had to be over by 11:30 p.m. He's got work early tomorrow.

21.

Igor. Okay, but do you think it's possible that if you were into some guy, well, more like a man, who takes care of himself, he's already 50, let's say, but looks 35, and he's in good shape, he's cool, an interesting person too, and even kind of young in the head. Could you be into that?

Rostislav. Yes.

Igor. And why?

Rostislav. Why not, if he's hot and everything's, like, good. Why wouldn't I be into that?

Igor. Well, he's older, he's gonna age faster than you, you realize like, okay, right now it's all fine, but 10-15 years go by and... I mean, I get that it sounds dumb and cynical, but obviously chances are he'll die before you, for example.

Rostislav. Okay, are we talking about a relationship, like, would I get into a twenty-year relationship with a man like that, or just sex with him?

Igor. Yeah, I mean a relationship.

Rostislav. Well, I don't know, like... I haven't had an experience like that. You're not that much older than me to talk about stuff like that, but even with you I can feel the age difference, and, like, sometimes I think yeah, it'd be easier for me, or kind of more interesting, with a person my age.

Igor. Uh-huh. (writes it down)

Rostislav. What the fuck are you writing down? Right, he finds people his own age more interesting?

Igor. Yeah it's not the first time I'm hearing this from you.

Rostislav. And then it fucking turns out this whole thing isn't a play and you just wanted to grill me about our relationship or whatever. You're such a sneak.

22.

Haidhausen.

Martin again. The one who called me Schlampe. Not the office this time. His friend's apartment. First time I stayed over at someone's for the whole night.

23.

Igor. So what do we do with this?

Rostislav. I don't know. It's like you want to decide it all in advance?

Igor. No, I don't. I just wanted to try and imagine it.

Rostislav. Last time we imagined we were breaking up, I couldn't get over it for weeks after. You're now digging into this whole thing about our hypothetical breakup, and with such enthusiasm too, like you're trying this scenario on, like it already feels real to you.

Igor. I'm tired of always taking the initiative. Obviously there's a problem. We could talk about it with a therapist, we could…

Rostislav. I feel like I'm getting backed into a corner with all this talk right now. And it's unpleasant, because it feels like it's my fault for some reason.

Igor. I tried acting differently and it never once worked.

Rostislav. Why were you so keen yesterday on going over to someone's?

Igor. I don't know, I just felt like it.

Rostislav. But why?

Igor. You're saying it like there's some second layer to it and you just figured out something incredible about me.

Rostislav. I'm honestly surprised by the fact that before me you were in totally monogamous relationships. But at the same time, I know you as someone who's really into sex on the side. Your eyes light up like a kid's whenever the possibility of it comes up.

24.

Berg am Laim. East Munich.

We live in this same neighborhood.

A lawyer. When you walk down the hallway to his apartment, you can see our balcony, mine and Rost's, from the window.

25.

Alyona. Basically, open relationships are cool, but I don't think it's, like, some kind of relationship of the future. I don't think that sooner or later everyone has to get there. And in general, I don't see it as a cure-all even in my own life. I'm into different formats, different periods of my life, I need something different, and I think the main thing about it is to listen really carefully to what you feel and to understand what you want at this specific moment, and on top of that it's also important to understand that at the very beginning, when you've only just met, and you're in some kind of, I don't know, flirting phase, it's totally normal not to know what you want from each other. All that only gets figured out with time, with the experience of listening to yourself and to your partner, your partner and partners. And I think it's really important here not to bullshit yourself, like "nah, I'm not jealous at all, I'm not anything, I don't give a damn who

he's fucking". I mean, like, really paying attention to your own feelings. If there's something you don't like, that's a reason to at least think about it, figure it out on your own.

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Andrey. I get the feeling that a lot of immature people practice, well, more like, arm themselves with the idea of open relationships so they can get pleasure while destroying something important for themselves and for others in the long run. Or just, like, slapping a band-aid somewhere over there where it hurts. And as for the wonderful, amazing, beautiful side of it: I genuinely think it exists. But the culture has to be ready for stuff like this to work well. But right now the monogamous thing is what dominates. But I genuinely believe that mature, grown-up people can take on that risk, get the good out of it, negate the bad.

26.

Rost and I have a talk planned for today about what happened with each of us this week, who was stressing about what, plans for the future. It's a normal conversation we have regularly.

Rost says today he definitely has to go first.

When we were on vacation in Georgia, he told me he was going to see his therapist, but actually he had sex with some big jacked broski from Grindr. When we flew back to Germany, they started texting and calling. That's also when they told each other they might've fallen in love. Half-jokingly started making plans to move together to the US and shoot porn together.

Rost said he can't keep quiet about all this anymore and decided to tell me everything.

End of part one.

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